

MSI Mega PC 180

Mini-entertainment-gaming-arsenal

MSI entertainment and gaming appliance (MEGA) are series of small form factor bare-bone PCs. Mega PC 180 is a complete new product, re-defining the future of bare-bone PCs.

The Mega 180 is encased in an elegant, jet-black casing. The front bezel incorporates a colourful LED panel, similar to ones found on a consumer audio product. What differentiates the Mega 180 from other bare-bones is the fact that you can use it as a stand-alone audio appliance that can play audio CDs, MP3 CDs and AM/FM radio without switching on the PC.

The play, pause, forward, reverse and mode buttons are provided just below the LED panel for easy access. Two buttons let you toggle between the Hi-Fi mode and the PC mode. A 6-in-1 card-reader is placed below the LED panel. A push button smoothly opens a plastic flap to reveal two USB, two Firewire and an SPDIF optical-in ports at the bottom of the front bezel. The optional TV-tuner card can be controlled by the accompanying system remote.

The Mega 180 is based around an nForce2 chipset supporting AMD Athlon XP 3000+ and DDR 333 via two memory slots. It offers a dual-monitor out to connect two monitors. The board offers an 8X AGP slot and a PCI slot for add-on cards. Installing current-generation video cards will leave no space for any PCI card to be plugged into the PCI slot. The back panel has four USB ports, an Ethernet connector and six-channel audio with SPDIF optical-out. For efficient cooling, MSI has provided cus-



tom-made full copper heat sink with two lateral fans. The sides of the casing are perforated for better air circulation. The interiors are cramped, and installing drives is a cumbersome job.

The nForce2 does not disappoint and like all MSI motherboards handles system-intensive applications very well. Priced at Rs 19,000, the Mega PC 180 is definitely expensive, but it's the only one of its kind available in the market today and this exclusivity is what the price is about.

■ **Specifications:** nForce2+MCP-T chipset, six USB ports, two Firewire ports, AM/FM tuner, MP3 player and optional TV-tuner card

■ **Price:** Rs 19,000

■ **Contact:** Cyberstar

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■ **Overall Rating:** ★★★★★

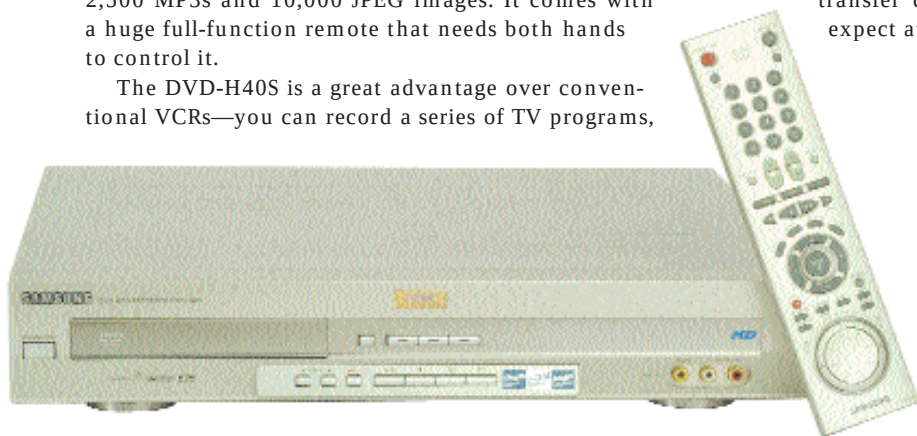
Samsung DVD HDD Recorder DVD-H40S

Move away VCR

The DVD-equivalent to a VCR, the Samsung DVD-H40S plays DVDs, and stores programs, images, etc, on its inbuilt 40 GB hard disk. It has a friendly GUI that lets you choose between two storage modes—40 hours of video, 250 MP3s and 10,000 JPEG images, or 30 hours of video, 2,500 MP3s and 10,000 JPEG images. It comes with a huge full-function remote that needs both hands to control it.

The DVD-H40S is a great advantage over conventional VCRs—you can record a series of TV programs,

and start watching stuff while it's still recording. Record videos at 2, 4 and 6 Mbps. The video output is excellent. It has optical and co-axial digital output ports, plus input ports for a camcorder, VCD, VCR and sound system. The only drawback is the lack of CD or DVD-writing support, and an interface to transfer data to and from a PC—something one would expect at Rs 45,000.



■ **Specifications:** DVD, VCD, MP3 and CD playback, Dolby Digital and DTS support, 40 GB hard disk, video-in/out jacks, component video-out jacks, S-video in-out jacks, one digital optical audio out, one digital coaxial audio out, RF antenna input and output

■ **Price:** Rs 44,990

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■ **Overall Rating:** ★★★★★